STATUS REPORT

Sao Tome and Principe: status report

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GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Public Administration is the only one of São Tomé and Príncipe's 16 governance sub-categories in the Ibrahim Index to fall in Africa's bottom ten, at 44.6 out of 100 in 2023, 41st of 54 and down 3.2 points over 2014-2023, even as its Effective Administration indicator rose 5.1 points to 53.6 — a striking weakness in a country whose Overall Governance score of 59.2 ranks 12th of 54 African states, up 0.7 points over the decade but down 0.9 over the most recent five years (2023). The same profile makes Foundations for Economic Opportunity, which covers public administration, the business environment, infrastructure and the rural economy, the weakest category at 43.4 out of 100, 41st of 54 and up only 0.3 points over 2014-2023, against a wider picture in which the country scores above the African average on 64 of its 96 indicators.

The written policy base is thin and largely predates the current programme. The 2020 National Strategy for Digital Governance sets out nine thematic axes and proposes an authentication platform with single sign-on tied to digital identity, and a single government portal at GOV.ST; a National Framework for Interoperability followed on the same government site in 2021, the two together forming the published governance documentation for the data exchange programme, which has no public dashboard or real-time reporting. More recently the government has approved a public-administration reform strategy whose essential pillar is electronic governance, aimed at rationalising processes, cutting bureaucracy and costs and promoting equity of access to public services (June 2025), and the central bank's fintech sandbox sits under the National Financial Inclusion Strategy rather than standing as a one-off initiative (June 2025).

The national data strategy has since been issued: INIC published version 1 of a national data strategy and implementation roadmap in July 2025, setting objectives for responsible and ethical data use and data-based decision-making and treating artificial intelligence as an opportunity to be explored using public data rather than as anything already in operation. Against that, there is no national AI strategy and no AI-specific legislation, UNESCO recommending approval of a national AI strategy law by 2027 or 2028. Much of the rest is still being written: the identity strategy and modernisation roadmap is an unmet project target, and the regulator put the 2024-2028 national cybersecurity strategy and its action plan to a 30-day public consultation in September 2025. Separately, the country held a national Data Governance Capacity Building Workshop on 9-10 July 2026 on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework domestically, run by the D4D Hub with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet.

Legislation and regulation

São Tomé and Príncipe has no aggregated identification document law in force, an absence the World Bank's September 2025 mission flagged as urgent because it could constrain the data collection the new digital identity depends on. Civil identification still rests on colonial-era Decree 251/71, updated by Decree 09/2018 on digitisation, which the World Bank assesses as outdated and scattered with gaps for digital identity, no dedicated digital ID regulation having been enacted (2024).

Other digital legislation is part-finished. An electronic signature law has been passed, while an Electronic Communications Law and a Law on Regulatory Authorities have been approved by the Council of Ministers and await the National Assembly (2025). A law establishing automatic and permanent voter registration entered into force in 2026, formalising data sharing between the civil registry directorate and the National Electoral Commission. A national interoperability framework gives public authorities a legal basis for sharing data (2024), and no interoperability solution was operational as at September 2025. Two absences shape what the rest of the statute book can do. There is no access-to-information statute: Artigos 29, 74 and 76 of the constitution guarantee free expression, place a duty on office-holders to keep citizens informed and make unpublished laws legally ineffective, and none of the three creates a request procedure, deadline, exemption, appeal or oversight body. And there is no AI law or regulation and no national AI ethics body, the data protection framework and its authority standing as the only anchors. The oldest instrument still doing work is the statistical one: Lei n. 5/98 defines the Sistema Estatistico Nacional, names its organs and creates the statistics institute in Artigo 7.

The settled parts of the statute book are data protection, cybercrime and payments. Lei n. 15/2017, gazetted on 6 October 2017 and in force thirty days later, creates the computer-crime offences, sets procedural powers of expedited preservation, search, seizure and interception for electronic evidence, and requires the Policia Judiciaria to keep a permanent 24-hour international cooperation contact point. The payment system rests first on Lei n. 17/2018, the enacting law of the national payment system, which makes the central bank regulator and overseer and is framed on the secure transfer of funds between individuals, commercial entities and financial institutions. Law No. 03/2016, promulgated on 10 May 2016 and modelled on the EU's Directive 95/46/EC, applies to personal data processed by public and private bodies, with Law No. 07/2017 establishing the National Data Protection Agency as its enforcement body. It obliges controllers to notify the agency at least eight days before processing begins but imposes no post-breach notification duty, so no mandatory data-breach notification applies to payment or other personal data. The national payment system runs on Decree-Laws 01/2017 and 06/2017, which establish the operator SPOUT, NAP 01/2012 on bank card issuance and use, and NAP 09/2019 with Decree-Law 16/2019 on electronic funds transfers and payment service providers, and the central bank's own Organic Law, Law 03/2025, creates an audit committee over its accounts.

Data protection

On 1 June 2026 Macau's Personal Data Protection Bureau signed a cooperation memorandum with São Tomé and Príncipe's ANPDP, authorised by Macau's Chief Executive Sam Hou Fai, covering cross-border data flows, supervision of artificial intelligence, public awareness, training and joint studies. The São Toméan delegation presented on the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence, and also visited Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association (June 2026). A year earlier the same agency was in Lisbon, where a cooperation visit to Portugal's CNPD identified disinformation on social media, rising digital violence and videosurveillance as the two regulators' shared concerns, alongside the need to train data subjects, particularly children and young people (June 2025). Macau frames this outreach as strengthening the chain of cooperation between China and the Portuguese-speaking countries on data security and privacy.

The Agência Nacional de Proteção de Dados Pessoais is also active at home. It worked with Facebook in January 2025 to remove fake profiles impersonating public figures, and, chaired by José Manuel Costa Alegre, it supervises the interconnection between the civil registry and electoral databases, which it will assess once the linkage has been inspected (April 2026).

What the law gives citizens is narrower than what it promises. Law No. 03/2016 grants rights of access, correction and deletion, but there is no online portal or digital mechanism through which a person can view their own identity data, and access requires an in-person request to the civil registry directorate or the agency (2024). Articles 19 and 20 restrict transfers of personal data outside the national territory unless the destination offers an adequate level of protection, with no sector-specific localisation requirement standing in place of that general rule, and the absence of any duty to notify a breach after the fact leaves the regime weighted towards prior notification of processing rather than incident response.

Regional collaboration

São Tomé and Príncipe is a third country to West Africa's data regime: ECOWAS Supplementary Act A/SA.1/01/10 on Personal Data Protection confines itself by its Article 3(3) to processing carried out in a UEMOA or an ECOWAS member state, and being a Supplementary Act of the Authority it binds those states directly without transposition. The practical consequence sits in Article 36, under which personal data may leave an ECOWAS member state for a non-member country only where that country offers an adequate level of protection and only on prior notification of the transferring state's data protection authority.

Membership of neither ECOWAS nor the West African Economic and Monetary Union puts the country outside the region's digital machinery entirely: the ECOWAS identity, customs-transit, roaming and data-protection instruments and the BCEAO's regional clearing, settlement and instant-payment rails carry no obligation for it and give it no access (September 2026).

Its collaboration runs on other axes. The data protection agency is a founding member of the Rede Lusófona de Proteção de Dados, set up in 2024 with the authorities of Portugal, Angola, Brazil and Cabo Verde, Brazil holding the presidency and Portugal the permanent secretariat (June 2025), a network Macau's data protection bureau joined in April 2026 — putting the Portuguese-language regulators of Europe, Africa, Latin America and China in one room. Bilateral work with Cabo Verde extends beyond the regulator: the two countries signed protocols in January 2024 to computerise the justice sector. The country's own regional bloc supplies a legal floor rather than infrastructure, with ECCAS free movement and establishment rights giving migrants a basis for access to financial services (2025), while cross-border payments still rely on banks' SWIFT access through the central bank rather than any regional instant payment link. At continental level the country worked on domestic adoption of the African Union Data Policy Framework at a July 2026 national workshop, and in November 2025 it hosted a three-day workshop of the Lusophone regulators' association and the ITU on promoting and measuring universal and meaningful connectivity, which closed on a joint commitment to continued regulatory harmonisation among Portuguese-speaking countries.

Standards

The country has a national quality body and it is a junior member of the international system: SENAPIQ-STP is a public institute with administrative, financial, technical and asset autonomy under the finance ministry, its functions including proposing policies on industrial property, copyright, standardisation, certification and accreditation, and it is the country's correspondent member of the International Organization for Standardization. No national standards catalogue, accreditation register or certification scheme is published, and the one certification on record is private: BGFI Bank Sao Tome became the first bank in the country certified to ISO 9001:2015 in August 2026. Beyond that the standards in use are inherited rather than chosen. The customs administration is preparing to move to ASYFIVE,

the United Nations successor to the ASYCUDA system used in more than 103 countries (January 2026), and the passport issuing system launched in April 2026 uses a biographic-page technique from Portugal's Imprensa Nacional-Casa da Moeda.

São Tomé and Príncipe is building its foundational identity system on open standards: a system integrator, Ooru, was contracted in September 2025 to design a new bilhete de identidade as a digital ID, jointly led by INIC and the civil registry directorate DGRN, on the open-source MOSIP platform. Working prototypes of the surrounding stack — a verifiable credentials infrastructure, a data-exchange and interoperability platform, a citizen portal and app, and an e-signature service — were built to open standards with the source code made available to the government (September 2025).

Public debate and participation in policymaking

São Tomé and Príncipe has Africa's freest civic and digital space and a shrinking role for the public in making policy. Its civil society space scores 91.2 out of 100 in the 2023 Ibrahim Index, first of 54 African states and unchanged over the decade, while Deliberative & Participatory Governance — how far policy is made through consultation — scores 61.5, 22nd of 54 and down 4.0 points over 2014-2023. On speech the country ranks near the top of the continent, at 93.1 out of 100 for Freedom of Expression & Belief, second of 54, and 70.4 for Media Freedom, sixth of 54, both slightly down over the decade, and public perception of freedom of speech rose 14.2 points over 2014-2023 to 86.8, third of 54 and among the country's ten most improved indicators. The online dimension matches it: the index's Digital Freedom indicator, covering online censorship, government internet shutdowns and surveillance, scores the country 88.9 out of 100 in 2023, first of 54 African states and essentially unchanged over the decade.

The constraint is not what citizens may say but what they can get hold of and act on. The country scores poorly on the accessibility of public records and online government services, better but still low on disclosure of budgets, asset declarations and official documents, and its representation of rural populations in decisions that affect them is among its most deteriorated measures of the decade (2023).

Electoral participation is where the digital and the deliberative meet. The reform of the electoral system was designed to answer the recommendations of the European Union election observation mission of 2022, and the new registration system was declared ready in February 2026 for the general elections held that July and September. Where the public sphere itself has come under pressure, the response has been regulatory rather than restrictive: the data protection agency's removal of impersonating profiles from Facebook in January 2025 is the clearest instance.

Two consultation routes are on the record, and both are the regulator's. AGER launched a public consultation on the draft electronic communications law in February 2024 and published a report setting out its legal basis and its point-by-point responses to the contributions received, and in September 2025 it put the 2024-2028 national cybersecurity strategy and its action plan to public comment, with contributions due within 30 days and later submissions excluded. Neither records what it changed. Outside the regulator, participation has been local and small: two districts turned resident-identified priorities into completed works in six and a half months through pilot participatory budgeting exercises, paving a road in Cantagalo and building a water capture and distribution system in Lemba (August 2026), run by civil-society organisations with the district councils and Portuguese and European support.

Finance

Financial sustainability

The World Bank project that installed the central bank's core banking system closed in June 2025 having paid for the system's testing, technical support and licensing for two years beyond its close (December 2025), and the Digital São Tomé and Príncipe grant behind the identity, interoperability and connectivity work runs to 2027.

The digital lines of the 2024 budget come to STN 92.6 million appropriated, of which STN 33.6 million, or 36.3%, is the state's own money (2024).

The external side of those lines is led by World Bank grants for the population census, STN 27.5 million, and the Príncipe fibre project, STN 10 million, with French Development Agency grants for treasury and tax systems and an African Development Bank loan of STN 4 million for the payment system (2024). Among the state's own lines are the statistics institute's running transfer of STN 9.6 million and STN 5.8 million for the running of the Innovation and Knowledge Institute, INIC (2024).

Four registry and IT units spend earmarked revenue of their own under the 2024 budget: the geographic and cadastral service STN 7.9 million, the registries and notary directorate STN 5.2 million, the business one-stop shop STN 0.5 million and the justice ministry's informatics centre STN 0.3 million (2024). The national cybersecurity strategy records that the ICT competence centre created in 2002 did not survive for lack of financial sustainability.

MoUs and other agreements

The agreements on record are diplomatic frames rather than digital programmes. The bilateral relationship with China was elevated to a strategic partnership in Beijing on 5 September 2024, announced by the two heads of government with no financial terms, sums or sectoral annexes stated in the signing party's own release. India's own country brief records a protocol for foreign office consultations of December 2009, an economic cooperation agreement and a traditional medicines memorandum of March 2018, and a framework agreement on space cooperation signed in September 2018.

Two instruments do carry digital content. The tax directorate signed a memorandum with the tourism directorate on 9 February 2026 creating a permanent mechanism for sharing data on licensed tourism and hospitality businesses, cross-checking registration and tax compliance and reinforcing the obligation to issue electronic invoices, the only inter-agency data-sharing instrument on record. The country's consulate in Berlin states that the citizenship and investment unit has signed a contract with Atlas Sovereign Smart Solutions, led by IOPn with Betabytes, to mobilise up to ten billion US dollars over ten years for a modular data centre, an AI academy, an AI factory, digital identity systems, a digital finance ministry and a Web3 free trade zone (October 2025) - the figure and the scope are that page's own claims, no counterparty document was located, and nothing records any of it as begun.

New investments

Sao Tome and Principe takes in the highest official development assistance per head of any African state, USD 233.7 (2023), first of 54 on a population of 0.2 million and a GDP of USD 0.6 billion; the digital share of that flow is small and comes almost wholly from the development banks.

The World Bank's Digital Sao Tome and Principe project (P177158), a USD 22 million grant approved in June 2022 and running to 2027, is the largest single live external commitment to the country's digital economy, funding connectivity, digital public services and digital skills. The older of the two is the African Development Bank's Payment System and Financial Inclusion Infrastructure Project, XDR 2.4 million as a grant on a window running from

2017 to 2027, for internationalising the national payment system, securing lending and developing electronic payment instruments, and still active on that window. The Bank returned to the same system in 2023 with a loan agreement to add real-time gross settlement and automated clearing house functions to the national switch.

Three further commitments were made in the twelve months to September 2026. The African Development Fund approved a US$24.5 million grant in April 2026 anchoring a US$30 million energy transition project running to November 2031, the World Bank proposed a US$10 million grant in March 2026 for a development policy operation on fiscal sustainability, energy access and digital connectivity - the first operation to carry a national broadband-use target - and the Bank signed US$6 million in additional financing for the social protection project in October 2025.

Smaller external support sits outside the banks. The trade single window and ASYFIVE deployment carries UNDP technical and financial backing (January 2026), and the EU-funded electoral system reform project, delivered through Portuguese Cooperation, closed in September 2025. Identity modernisation is externally funded as well, through a World Bank IDA grant and the Gates Foundation by way of MOSIP, against a registration directorate whose own card-fee revenue does not sustain it.

Two multilateral commitments name the country directly. The regional digital integration and regional identification programmes financing its West African neighbours run through ECOWAS and WAEMU, to which it does not belong, so none of them reaches it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

Príncipe is off the fixed network: the island's average fixed broadband speed stood at 0.00 Mbps against 8.3 Mbps on São Tomé in September 2025, the supply contract for its submarine cable was still unsigned, and none of the 70 schools targeted for new broadband access had yet benefited.

Satellite has begun filling part of the gap. Starlink activated service in the country in December 2025, and the free national identity card campaign now reaches remote localities on a Starlink link and a portable generator supplied by the PReSE electoral reform project (January 2026).

On the main island the incumbent CST launched commercial 4G in August 2023 across 102 antennas in 34 locations and inaugurated a further antenna at Água Izé in Cantagalo district in March 2026, ending a prolonged period of network instability there. An Electronic Communications Law and a Law on Regulatory Authorities have cleared the Council of Ministers but await the National Assembly (2025).

The regulator publishes its own series. For 2023 it records 5,775 fixed broadband subscribers at 2.6 per 100 inhabitants, 96,901 active mobile broadband accesses at 43.3 per 100 and 146,497 active mobile voice subscribers at 65.5 per 100, with installed international broadband capacity of 35,840 Gb against 6,122 Gb used. The first target the state has signed up to arrived in March 2026, a financing operation setting people using broadband, inferred use, at 146,000 in December 2025 rising to 172,000 by December 2028, with the female figure at 74,000 rising to 87,000. Domestic traffic has nowhere to meet: there is no active internet exchange point and none listed in the peering directory, with an internet resilience score of 30 out of 100 and half of the thousand most-visited sites reachable from an in-country server or cache. Retail prices are published rather than assessed - the incumbent's mobile bundles run from 10 dobras for 24 hours to 330 dobras for 30 days, the largest carrying 4,000 MB.

Signal is not the constraint: 96% of the population was covered by an LTE or WiMAX network in 2024, while 59.1% used the internet that year, against 58.7% in 2023, and mobile connections stood at about 170,000 in 2025, equal to 71.4% of a population of some 238,000.

The long trend is real but starts low. Infrastructure is the worst-scoring of the country's 16 IIAG sub-categories at 34.4 out of 100 in 2023, 31st of 54 African states, up 3.2 points over 2014-2023; mobile communications rose 30.2 points to 65.9, the third most improved of 96 indicators, and internet and computers rose 14.0 points to 38.1, still below 40. The floor is physical delivery rather than telecommunications: shipping and postal networks score 1.6 out of 100, 52nd of 54 and the country's lowest indicator of all.

None of it has reached the public's judgement. Perception of infrastructure fell 29.0 points over 2014-2023 to 36.0 out of 100 — the third most deteriorated indicator in the country's profile, and a fall recorded while the measured score was rising.

Data Storage

The government's only data centre is in the wrong place: it sits at sea level, the risks there were rated high enough for the consultancy assessing it to recommend moving government systems and data to a new data centre or to the cloud, and requalifying the present site was costed at about EUR 0.5 million against about EUR 4.6 million for a new TIER III build (September 2025).

There is no commercial alternative onshore — the country records no commercial data centres (2024) — so critical systems sit abroad. The civil registration system SIGA is hosted in Portugal at the University of Aveiro, a foreign infrastructure dependency the World Bank flags as a business continuity risk (2024).

Both ends of the choice are now being pursued at once. A World Bank mission recommended in September 2025 that the digital identity system move to a TIER III data centre or to cloud hosting, and in May 2026 the project's fiduciary agency AFAP tendered for data-centre servers and disaster recovery capacity for that system.

The state's own position is that it should not be. INIC states that storing and hosting the country's vital information and systems in national territory is an imperative of security and sovereignty, and offers hosting to the whole public administration, inviting private bodies to use it; the draft cybersecurity strategy names dependence on external hosting of data and structuring services, including citizens' personal information and critical infrastructure, as an aggravating factor, and describes no backup or disaster-recovery capability anywhere in the state estate. The estate it describes is older than the data centre's current management: the government data centre and the government network date from 2008 and the government fibre backbone was begun in 2017.

Where the data may go is governed by the general regime rather than a localisation rule: Law No. 3/2016 restricts transfers of personal data outside the national territory unless the destination offers an adequate level of protection, with no sector-specific requirement layered on top.

Energy

What limits power is supply rather than connection. The sector runs under Decreto-Lei n. 26/2014, the legal regime organising the national electricity sector, gazetted on 31 December 2014 as part of a reform of the sector. Load shedding runs to between three and seven hours a day (2024), even though electricity access reached about 84% of the population that year.

Access itself is comparatively even by regional standards, at 81.9% of the urban population against 69.6% of the rural population in 2023, a gap of 12.3 percentage points. Generation remains almost entirely thermal — renewables supply about 3% of electricity, and an off-grid policy is active with a mini-grid rollout planned (2024).

The utility's own figures show the supply position deteriorating over 2024: available capacity in the plants fell to 33.0 MW at 31 December 2024 from 39.0 MW in each of the two prior years, maximum capacity referred to production to 15.50 MW from 19.00 MW, and production to 60,764 MWh from 103,533 MWh, with combined

efficiency at 58.5 per cent. The state's own auditor found the newest thermal capacity billed but not delivered: the Court of Auditors' compliance and operational audit of the administrative investment contract with TESLA STP, report 02/2025, records that the five installed generators do not hold the 10 MW the contract defines and have produced roughly 4 MW since installation while the state is obliged to pay for 10 MW, that an investment claim of about 10.85 million euros is unsubstantiated, that customs and tax exemptions to the company and its group cost the state at least 52,282,555 dobras, and that the utility supplied 13,320,198 litres of fuel free of charge between December 2023 and December 2024 (May 2025); no state response, recovery or contract amendment is held. The most recent external statement puts daily outages at three to four hours, technical and commercial losses above 34 per cent of generation, and nearly 95 per cent of generation on imported fossil fuels at 0.30 dollars per kilowatt-hour (April 2026). The funded response arrived in April 2026: an African Development Fund grant of US$24.5 million anchoring a US$30 million project to build a 4 MWp solar plant with a 2 MWh battery on Principe, rehabilitate its low-voltage networks, modernise the national dispatch centre, install over 40,000 prepaid meters and create 2,000 new connections.

The index reading tracks the same picture: access to energy scored 40.8 out of 100 in 2023, 27th of 54 African states, up 6.2 points over 2014-2023.

The cost of unreliable power lands on the systems built on top of it. A 2023 assessment found that many schools are not using the national SIGE education management system because they lack electricity, computers or internet, or find it hard to use.

Technical Capacity

Three institutions now teach at degree level in the field. The higher education directorate's register of accredited courses lists computer engineering at the university's Faculty of Sciences and Technologies and at ULSTP, and telecommunications and computer engineering and business computing at IUCAI, with only accredited enrolments legally recognised. The wider assessment of what the state can run is the World Bank's: a fragmented approach to digitization, most of the foundations for digital government service delivery still nascent, and the country 155th of 193 on the 2020 e-government index and 179th of 193 on the 2018 e-participation index (2022).

Public administration is the state's weakest arm and it is getting weaker: it is the only one of the 16 IIAG sub-categories in Africa's bottom ten, scoring 44.6 out of 100 in 2023, 41st of 54 and down 3.2 points over 2014-2023, even as its effective administration indicator rose 5.1 points to 53.6. The wider category it sits in, foundations for economic opportunity, scores 43.4 out of 100, 41st of 54 and up only 0.3 points over the same decade.

That thinness shows in how core systems are run. The DGRN relies on external vendors for its core systems and hosts civil registration abroad (2024), and identity modernisation is funded from outside — a World Bank IDA grant of over USD 16.25 million and the Gates Foundation through MOSIP — with the registry resource-constrained and card fee revenue insufficient to sustain it.

Where capability does exist it has been built programme by programme. The health ministry runs DHIS2 nationally, with tablets and computers issued to facilities and staff trained to enter data at the point of care for named vertical programmes including HIV, TB, malaria and routine immunisation (2023), and in January 2026 UNODC delivered computers and secure data storage equipment to the Polícia Judiciária headquarters for criminal investigation work. The clearest instance of a handover designed for what happens afterwards is the fisheries registry: in April 2026 the FAO trained technicians of the fisheries directorate, the fisheries inspectorate, the coastguard and the port captaincy on a new vessel registration system, moving registration from paper to an Android application feeding a central database and leaving a user manual as permanent support so the system continues in use after the training.

Cybersecurity

The statute is old and operative and the strategy is not: Lei n. 15/2017 has been in force since 2017, creating the computer-crime offences and the procedural powers for electronic evidence and requiring a permanent 24-hour police contact point for international cooperation, while the strategy that would organise a capability around it went to a 30-day public consultation, run by AGER on the 2024-2028 text and its action plan, only in September 2025. The drafting document itself names dependence on external hosting of data and structuring services as an aggravating factor and sets objectives on resilience of critical infrastructures, incident response plans and a national response team. The final text, version 2 of 15 December 2023, sets five strategic objectives - coordination through a Cybersecurity Committee and a national incident response centre, CERT-STP; awareness and a security culture; capability through training and curricula; consolidation of the legal structure, which it records as lacking any specific legislation on protecting children online; and adoption of good practice including international standards in software and hardware procurement - and puts the strategy to an annual evaluation by the committee against yearly performance targets, though the action plan's own tracking grids are blank templates in the document. The World Bank's account of what stands behind it is thin: a mission in September 2025 listed launching the incident response team, the CSIRT, among its five objectives, so the body the strategy turns on was still being brought into existence two years after the text was final.

The index reading is consistent with that. São Tomé and Príncipe sits in the Evolving tier of the ITU Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, the band for scores of 20 to 55 out of 100, one of sixteen African states placed there.

Nor does anyone have to say when something goes wrong. Law No. 3/2016 requires controllers to notify the data protection agency at least eight days before processing begins but imposes no post-breach notification duty, so a compromise of payment or other personal data carries no reporting obligation.

DPI

Data Exchange

The one link between two government databases carrying live national business is the electoral one: a platform built by the University of Aveiro under the EU- and Portuguese-funded electoral reform project, connecting the SIGA civil register and the identity card system to the electoral database, was substantially built and awaiting legal review in September 2025 and went into service when automatic and permanent voter registration was inaugurated at the end of April 2026, ending the repeated manual censuses. Nothing equivalent exists at the centre of government: the World Bank's Digital STP project recorded no operational interoperability solution as of September 2025, against a target of June 2027, with no government system connected to one.

Institutional access to civil registry data instead runs through the Leginon platform over a secure VPN, supporting basic queries rather than system-to-system exchange - the directorate's own page claims more for it, describing legi non as the interface to its life-events database and the route by which the root identification of all Sao Tomeans is to be carried out, allowing reliable machine-to-machine exchange between duly accredited public administration systems through protocols agreed in advance, while naming no system consuming it - and the join between civil registration and civil identification is thin: enrolment reuses SIGA data by QR code or name search, there is no automatic update, and no unique identification number ties the two together. The other working cross-sector connection links the Unified Social Registry to the health ministry's DHIS2 individual tracker for case management, a sectoral arrangement rather than a route into any national platform, and the national retail payment system is not integrated with any government-wide exchange for payments to people or businesses.

What is being built has a mandate six years older than the prototypes. Resolucao n. 35/2020 approves the digital governance strategy, creates the digital governance committee, and names an interoperability platform as the structuring layer for integrating and coordinating public services alongside an authentication platform on single sign-on integrated with digital identity management and a state certification infrastructure; the instrument mandates them and does not record them as built. What exists was shown to a World Bank mission in September 2025 as working prototypes of a verifiable credentials infrastructure, a data-exchange and interoperability layer, a citizen portal and app and an electronic signature service, all on open standards with the source code handed to the government; the documented scope adds digital forms but carries no analytics or fraud-detection capability. The Guiché Único business register went through a legal and ICT diagnostic toward becoming a modern, data-oriented registry, one of the first uses proposed for that platform. Separately, an integrated port and external-trade single window with the ASYFIVE customs platform is in preparation, intended to bring the ports and airports authorities, the central bank, the Treasury and the investment agency onto one traceable system.

Digital Identity and CRVS

A system integrator, Ooru, was contracted in September 2025 to design a new foundational bilhete de identidade as a digital ID, and the system was in a pilot phase on the open-source MOSIP platform in June 2025. The card in circulation is a physical document with no electronic elements, and identity records remain a mix of paper and digital because most legacy card holders were never entered in the digital database. Passports moved faster: a modernised issuance system, SEP 2.0, launched in April 2026 under a four-year contract with Portugal's state mint, and in March 2026 the foreign ministry opened non-presential issuance to citizens in the diaspora under Decreto-Lei n. 1/2026, on a signed application and a scanned copy of a valid Bilhete de Identidade whose authenticity the migration and borders service verifies - reliance on the credential as a document rather than authentication against a register, and the first system on record leaning on the national card at all. At the other end of the life course, free birth registration up to one year is now available in every maternity unit in the country, staffed by registry technicians and trained midwives and entered directly into the database from computers and printers at those points, with 3,077 births registered in 2025.

What limits the system is coverage. Around 90,000 people were in the digital identity database in October 2021 and roughly 98,000 after the 8,070 first-time cards issued in 2022, fewer than half of eligible residents against a population of some 219,000 to 240,000. Civil registration is compulsory within 30 days of birth but the card itself is optional in practice, and many adults use the cédula pessoal drawn from their birth certificate instead; issuance or renewal normally costs STN 100, rising to STN 160 for very urgent processing. Two campaigns have pushed against that: a DGRN mobile brigade issuing the card free to every citizen reaching majority, working through Ilhéu das Rolas and Porto Alegre from January 2026, and cards for São Toméans in Portugal, available for collection at the Lisbon embassy from June 2026. The system is open only to nationals and the diaspora, with no route for refugees, asylum seekers or permanent residents, while the card or cédula is required to open a bank account, activate a SIM, reach basic public health services and join the flagship Vulnerable Families Program.

The modernisation is almost entirely externally funded, through a World Bank IDA grant of over USD 16.25 million and the Gates Foundation via MOSIP, with card fee revenue insufficient for sustainability; the financing project was 36% disbursed by September 2025. Know-your-customer checks are still manual, with electronic KYC proposed but not available, and publication of an identity strategy and modernisation roadmap had not happened as of September 2025.

Digital Payments and Fintech

The central bank launched the country's first fintech sandbox in June 2025, structured as a five-phase incubator rather than a standing authorisation regime, with reducing the volume of cash in the economy an explicit objective.

It starts from a very small base. The 2021-2025 inclusion strategy reports the 2017 demand-side survey finding that 76 per cent of the population over 18 was excluded from the financial system, that 39 per cent of respondents and 15 per cent of women held a bank account, and that the inclusion rate was around 0.24 and 0.18 for women, and the central bank's second survey puts the overall financial inclusion index at 0.41 in 2025 against 0.24 in 2017 - still 'moderate' on the AFI scale - the women's index at 0.34 against 0.18, the gender banking gap at 4.8 percentage points against 20, and bank-account holding down 0.6 points, which it attributes to the low income of the 30 per cent of adults at the bottom; its financial literacy barometer averages 72 per cent across seven dimensions against 39 in 2017, a rise it says is partly a refinement of method. The report does not restate the headline adult exclusion rate, so the 76 per cent exclusion figure of 2017 has no direct 2025 counterpart. Merchant acceptance rested on 138 POS devices in December 2021, all run by SPOUT, which holds exclusive rights to operate terminals; and person-to-person transfers ran through banking channels, with no mobile money operator in the market at that date. The IIAG's access to banking services score fell 6.0 points over 2014-2023 to 20.0 out of 100 in 2023, 27th of 54 African states.

The plumbing is functional but dated. The Dobra24 interbank ATM and card network has run since October 2011 and is being modernised towards a national switch with disaster recovery and, later, real-time gross settlement; it was rebuilt on a system supplied by Portugal's SIBS from 2021, and the African Development Bank signed a USD 3.2 million loan in 2023 for the switch upgrade. The central bank both regulates and operates: it runs the SICOI clearing platform, holds national SWIFT access and owns 61% of SPOUT, and cross-border payments depend on that SWIFT access rather than any regional instant-payment link — the country sits outside the WAEMU rails the BCEAO operates, including the PI-SPI instant payment service that opened in September 2025.

Government payments have barely moved: civil service salaries are distributed through printed payment lists submitted to banks, and a plan to route them through the finance ministry, the central bank and SPOUT is proposed but not operational (2023). The exceptions are narrow: the Ke-Non social protection system has used a bank-based module through BISTP since 2023 to pay conditional cash transfers to more than 10,000 vulnerable families, the one substantial digital channel from state to citizen, and tourism fees have been collected by digital card since August 2025. Some taxes can be paid by electronically initiated bank transfer, though collection remains mostly cash or cheque. The revenue side is the most measured: 3,866 taxpayers were registered on the SIT-VAT system with VAT collections equivalent to 3.32 per cent of GDP at September 2024, and 22 per cent of Treasury and central bank processes were digitalized at October 2025 after installation of the central bank core banking system, with commercial bank interfaces at 20 per cent and cheque compensation at 23.

The first instrument compelling electronic settlement rather than enabling it arrived in March 2026. Article 9 of the 2026 budget law prohibits corporate and personal income taxpayers with organised accounting from making or receiving cash payments of 10,000 dobras or more, requires a means identifying the payee - bank transfer, POS and ATM terminals, nominative cheque or direct debit - and makes cash spending above the limit non-deductible. The supervisory frame around it was replaced the year before: Lei n. 3/2025, the central bank's new organic law, sets its attributions to regulate and oversee payment systems, license and supervise financial institutions, and carries the duty relied on for financial consumer protection and for inclusion and literacy, though nothing published sits behind that duty - no complaints procedure, ombudsman, disclosure rule or redress statistic. The central bank's payment-system statistics, last published on 28 August 2026, carry the Internet Banking series from 2014 and the interbank clearing series from 2013.

Registries

The electoral roll used for the 2026 elections was the first ever derived automatically from civil-registry data rather than from a separate enrolment exercise, and it inherited the registry's own omissions: 1,860 people of voting age were missing from the July 2026 lists through a process failure. The roll stood at 146,510 electors at the end of July 2026, against 142,191 at the presidential poll of 19 July, with a public inspection and update window running 1-8 August 2026.

The roll grew by 4,319 electors between the 19 July 2026 presidential poll and the end of that month, a rise of about 3.0 per cent.

The civil register beneath it is stronger. The DGRN implemented the SIGA registry management system by 2018, enabling digital registration of births, deaths, marriages and divorces nationwide, and trained registry staff and midwives now enter births directly into an electronic database at maternities, with paper forms being phased out (2026). Birth registration reached 98.6% of the population and about 99% of children under one in the 2019 MICS, and the IIAG's civil registration score rose 37.5 points over 2014-2023 to 62.5 out of 100, 24th of 54 African states in 2023 and the second most improved of its indicators.

Other registers lag well behind. The Unified Social Registry, established under Decree-Law 16/2018 and run by the social protection directorate on the Ke-Non system, covered about 12,000 families and 52,808 individuals after the second recertification and expansion reported in June 2026, up from 8,000 families. Land is the weakest: the Integrated Property Registration System had catalogued 131,219 real-estate and vehicle records by June 2025, just short of its revised target of 133,151, with real-estate records at 71,071 against a target of 113,000. The Guiché Único business register went through a legal and ICT diagnostic in September 2025 toward becoming a modern, data-oriented registry, with the registries directorate and INIC flagging the need for offline access given the limits of electricity and internet. The tax directorate is the outlier, maintaining a taxpayer identification register with online registration and filing, with electronic invoicing required under the VAT Code since 2020 and an electronic tax mailbox mandated by a 2023 decree; its identifier is in operational use across the business register, where the taxpayer card is required of the applicant, the identifier of shareholders, foreign non-resident partners and companies, and a negative certificate of tax debt to dissolve a company, and in February 2026 it created a permanent data-sharing mechanism with the tourism directorate.

One register does not exist at all. The postal base bill of 2022, which refers to a postal code system and an address database among the postal service obligations, was submitted for debate and the record consulted does not show it in force, so the property registry's estimated 162,000 property records sit behind no national addressing scheme. More than 12,500 households were on the single social registry in August 2026, with the vulnerable families programme to expand from 5,000 to 6,000 households.

Sectoral management information systems

The newest sectoral system is clinical rather than administrative: a teleconsultation service launched in June 2026 with the Brazilian state of Piauí's digital health programme provides remote medical consultations in the underserved district of Caué. Beneath it, the health ministry has deployed DHIS2 nationally, issuing tablets and computers to facilities and training staff to enter data at the point of care for vertical programmes including HIV, TB, malaria and routine immunisation, though maternal and child health data still come from record books and spreadsheets, sent from health post to health centre to the national programme (2023). Social protection runs on the Ke-Non system, adopted in May 2023 on the openIMIS platform, holding the Unified Social Registry and linked to the national civil registry for client identification.

Education's management information system, the SIGE, is operated by the ministry for school records and still being developed to link the central level to the districts rather than any government data exchange; the World Bank project that installed it put a computer for data management in each primary school and a connection to the planning directorate's online platform, but many schools are not using it for want of electricity, computers or internet, or because they find it hard to use. It is still being procured: specialist technical assistance in technological infrastructure, resource management and training for its implementation was tendered in April 2026, and a separate tender opened in May 2026 for a higher education institution to develop dashboards for national education supervision.

Justice and security are earlier still. São Tomé and Príncipe and Cabo Verde signed protocols in January 2024 to computerise the justice sector; an integrated case management system contracted in December 2022 covers police, prosecution, judiciary and prison services within the city of São Tomé in its first phase, and the national police is running its own computerisation programme. UNODC delivered computers and secure data storage to the Polícia Judiciária headquarters in January 2026, and in June 2026 a five-week programme gave the criminal justice chain an end-to-end digital-evidence capability, training judicial police officers, prosecutors and judges on extraction and decryption tools procured for the judicial police and stated to be in operational use, alongside a review of the legal framework against the UN Convention against Cybercrime. Land is where a system and a service have come apart: the property registry system held 105,535 real-estate and vehicle entries at March 2024 against a December 2024 target of 133,151, while in February 2026 the geographic and cadastral service was shut out of its rented premises after three and a half years of rent unpaid by the state, the director barred from his office and staff sent home. The health system has begun to be used rather than only fed: a university public-health dissertation used national platform data for 2022-2023 to estimate district-level incidence of hypertension, diabetes and stroke across five districts (July 2026), and the health digitisation project was put out for independent evaluation of the platform, mSupply and Instalacoes Inteligentes in April 2026. The systems the state uses to raise and manage money went the other way over the decade: tax and revenue mobilisation fell 11.3 points to 34.7 out of 100 and budgetary and financial management fell 19.4 points to 43.1 in the 2023 IIAG, 40th and 42nd of 54 African states. The national health development plan described the single clinical process in a pilot phase at the central hospital and the Agua Grande health area (2022). The state fiduciary agency extended the deadline of the tender for a new management information system for the water and electricity utility in August 2026; the new deadline and the contract value are not stated.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

INIC launched a beta version of the Portal do Cidadão, the single citizen portal, in March 2026, eighteen years after the institute was founded and six years after the national digital governance strategy proposed a single government portal at GOV.ST. The starting point is low: the country scored around 0.22 on the UN E-Government Development Index in 2024, ranking 154th and placing it in the index's low group.

Individual services have gone digital ahead of the portal. The embassy in Portugal has issued civil-registry documents directly since April 2025 — birth certificates, the polycarbonate identity card, criminal record certificates and certificates of capacity to marry — drawing on the SIGA register from abroad. A job-matching platform at emprego.st, launched in 2022 with ILO support and run by the labour ministry, lets seekers and employers register, and the tax directorate's online filing is the most established transactional channel. Against that, electors correcting their address or polling station in the August 2026 update window could do so only in person or over WhatsApp, a consumer messaging app standing in for a citizen service interface.

The largest piece in preparation is in trade: an integrated port single window, external-trade single window and ASYFIVE customs platform, supported technically and financially by UNDP, intended to cut clearance times and raise revenue, with ASYFIVE not yet running anywhere in Africa. A United Nations agency handed computing equipment to the tax directorate under an EU-funded regional programme in August 2026.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Sub-national government has no presence in Sao Tome and Principe's data exchange work: no district or regional system was taking part as at 2025. Where district administration does handle data it acts as a relay rather than an origin, health facilities keeping manual registers whose paper aggregates are entered into DHIS2 at district level — the district is the first point at which a rural record becomes digital, and it is the last point at which anything sub-national is done with it.

The one sub-national government to have stated its own position did so seven years ago. The Regiao Autonoma do Principe's 2019 development plan lists limited digitalisation of the island and the absence of regional cartography and a cadastre among its principal constraints, and puts a territorial cadastre among its objectives; no national instrument dedicated to digitising district or regional administrative records is held, and the cadastral service that would answer the request was shut out of its own premises in February 2026 over unpaid state rent.

Rural digital data capture

Sao Tome and Principe created a digital agricultural marketing platform in October 2025, built with FAO support to put producers directly in touch with consumers, and the Ministry of Agriculture opened field collection for the third General Agricultural Census in July 2025. Two further points of capture have opened since. Free birth registration up to one year is now available in every maternity unit in the country, entered directly into the database from computers and printers at those points and eliminating paper, with 3,077 births registered in 2025 (March 2026), and the health agency, with the ministry, began testing the digitalisation of vaccination data in the three priority districts of Agua Grande, Me-Zochi and Caue (April 2026). Policing has not followed: the national police's command and control system was to cover only the district of Agua Grande in a first phase from August 2023 and be extended gradually to the rest of the country, the police commander saying in August 2023 that it was still to be inaugurated and a UN agency giving the police 11 laptops in January 2024 to extend it; nothing held records the extension itself.

Routine capture at the point of service is still manual. A 2023 WHO assessment found maternal and child health data drawn from record books and spreadsheets and sent from health post to health centre to the national programme, and recommended moving from a manual record system to an electronic one. An assessment the same year for the Global Partnership for Education found that many schools are not using the national SIGE education management system for want of electricity, computers or internet, or because staff find it hard to use.

What stands behind that is physical. Rural households reach electricity at a materially lower rate than urban ones (2023), and the national energy compact rests near-term rural supply on an off-grid policy and a planned mini-grid rollout. Reach is thinner again off the main island, where the Principe submarine cable supply contract was still unsigned and the schools targeted for new broadband had yet to benefit (September 2025). Where capture has to happen regardless, the equipment travels with it: the free identity card brigade works remote localities off-grid on a satellite link and a portable generator (January 2026), and a teleconsultation service opened in the underserved district of Caue (June 2026).

The governance side has fallen back. The Ibrahim Index scores the Rural Economy sub-category at 49.3 out of 100 in 2023, 37th of 54 African states and 5.0 points below its 2014 level; its Rural Representation and Participation indicator, drawn from IFAD data on how far rural populations are represented in decisions that affect them, fell 20.6 points over the same decade to 49.0, the fifth most deteriorated of the country's 96 indicators.

Technology

AI

The first artificial intelligence the state will put in front of citizens is a justice service. In June 2026 UNODC and a Canadian justice organisation agreed an implementing partnership with the Ministry of Justice to build DireitosAoPovo.st, an access-to-justice platform carrying a legal-information chatbot trained on Sao Tomean legislation and grounded through retrieval-augmented generation, plus two encrypted reporting modules routing to the judicial police. It arrives ahead of any rule governing one: there is no AI-specific law or regulation and no national AI ethics commission or dedicated governance structure, the data protection framework and its authority standing as the only anchors and INIC's guidelines carrying no force of law, and no national AI strategy exists, UNESCO recommending approval of one by 2027 or 2028. The assessment argues the instrument must be a law rather than a policy, because matters bearing on personal rights are reserved to the National Assembly, and rates the AI strategy law low priority against four updates it rates high for 2024 or 2025: the data protection agency's 2017 organic law, the 2008 decree creating INIC, the 2020 resolution adopting the digital governance strategy, and the statistics institute's capacity, and its ministerial preface states the country is not prepared to implement artificial intelligence ethically, having neither a strategy nor an AI-specific law nor a national AI ethics commission. The state's own position is preparatory: its data strategy treats artificial intelligence as an opportunity to be explored using public data rather than as anything already in operation, and a two-day intensive on digitalisation and artificial intelligence for the public administration ran in April 2026. The one deployed system is in health operations rather than administration: a vector-control system that plans, assigns, executes and monitors anti-malaria operations, analysing satellite imagery to locate probable breeding sites and climate data to recommend timing, piloted over more than 160,000 people in 2022, with nothing recording it since. Nor is intelligence being built into the state's core systems. The data-exchange platform under construction with World Bank support covered verifiable credentials infrastructure, an interoperability and data-exchange layer, a citizen portal and mobile app, an electronic signature service and digital forms as at September 2025, with no artificial intelligence or analytics capability for fraud detection, data quality or prediction in its documented scope.

Artificial intelligence has reached Sao Tome and Principe as a supervision question rather than an industrial one: on 1 June 2026 Macau's Personal Data Protection Bureau signed a cooperation memorandum with the national data protection authority, the ANPDP, covering cross-border data flows, the supervision of artificial intelligence, public awareness, training and joint studies. The same month a Sao Tomean delegation in Macau presented the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence, and visited Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association.

ICT Industry

The domestic sector is six firms. The statistics institute's second business census puts section J, informacao e comunicacao, at 6 enterprises, 0.6 per cent of the total, employing 209 people, 152 men and 57 women on an employment table captioned 2019, and no earlier count is held against which to read a direction. No ICT sector policy or industry strategy had been adopted as at September 2026.

Innovation ecosystem

The incubator network is broader than a single facility and states a technology remit. The entrepreneurship ministry describes REINA as a network of incubators on both islands, built with UNDP, Unitel STP and BGFI Bank, offering structured physical spaces with meeting rooms, internet and access to tools, business management and technical support and complementary training, aimed at students, scientists, entrepreneurs and firms developing projects, products and services based on innovative technology, and it opened a central facility in the capital in 2022 with Ministry of Youth and UNDP support. Its practical output is a competition rather than a portfolio. An earlier innovation fund awarded up to US$5,000 each to 26 projects from a fund of US$130,000, drawing 456 valid applications and taking 27 of a further 73 into incubation; the second Empreende+ drew more than 150 applications, trained 33 people over five weeks and funded four projects at US$12,000, US$10,000 and two at US$8,000 (November 2025); and the third launched in July 2026 focused on women-led entrepreneurship, run by the finance ministry's entrepreneurship directorate with the incubator network and UNDP financing. Three editions on donor money, and no domestic funding line behind any of them.

The nearest thing to a technology-specific programme sits at the central bank, whose first fintech sandbox opened in June 2025 and is structured as a five-phase incubator running from capacity-building through product design and testing to results, rather than as a standing authorisation regime that a firm could enter and leave on its own initiative.

Sao Tome and Principe is not among the 133 economies covered by the WIPO Global Innovation Index 2024, so no innovation score or rank is published for the country, and comparisons that use the index as their frame leave it out entirely.

Capacity

Literacy

Education is one of the country's stronger showings in African governance measurement: education completion reached 69.6 out of 100 in the 2023 Ibrahim Index, tenth of 54 African states and 19.9 points above its 2014 level, with enrolment up 11.3 points to 59.4 and twelfth of 54.

Getting those pupils online has moved more slowly. CST and the Ministry of Education have been working to connect schools to the internet, larger schools first (January 2025), but none of the schools targeted for new broadband access under the World Bank's digital project had yet benefited (September 2025), and Príncipe was still without a working submarine cable contract or measurable fixed broadband speed at that date. The only survey measure of digital skills the country holds is adolescent-specific: the 2019 multiple indicator survey reports the percentage of girls and boys aged 15 to 19 able to carry out at least one of nine listed computer activities, as a development indicator, and no whole-population digital-literacy rate is published. Equipment has reached vocational schools where it has reached schools at all: 24 laptops, four projectors, four pairs of speakers and four projection screens went to dual-certification technical-vocational schools in Caue, Lemba and the Autonomous Region of Principe in October 2025, and in the civil service a two-day intensive on digitalisation and artificial intelligence ran for the public administration in April 2026, covering digital public infrastructure, ethics, governance and data protection. School-level data handling is further ahead than school-level connectivity: the World Bank project that installed the education management information system put a computer for data management in each primary school and a connection to the planning directorate's online platform, and the ministry runs it for school records, still developing it to link the central level to the districts (2023).

Training and skills

Three institutions hold accredited computing qualifications. The higher education directorate's register lists computer engineering at the university's Faculty of Sciences and Technologies and at ULSTP, and telecommunications and computer engineering and business computing at IUCAI, with only accredited enrolments legally recognised, against the Universidade de São Tomé e Príncipe, founded in 2014, teaching computer engineering, information technology and electrical and energy engineering through its Faculty of Sciences and Technologies. Its interim rector stated in May 2026 that challenges persist in financing, infrastructures, scientific research, digitalisation, internationalisation and academic quality, naming a shortage of teaching staff and low investment in science and innovation as the principal difficulties.

What comes out of it cannot be counted. The university graduated at least 94 students on 24 August 2026, 79 of them women, across agronomy, languages, law, public relations, public administration, tourism and technologies, with no breakdown by course, and no official publication counts graduates by field of study, ICT graduate destinations or the size of the national ICT professional workforce. The one traced destination is a single post: a computing graduate and a colleague built STP-DOC, described as the labour directorate's first digital platform and holding more than 10,000 documents, during a six-month paid traineeship in a programme that served more than 300 young people in a first phase and 60 in a second.

Beyond the university, skills work is externally funded and mostly aimed at officials rather than students. Digital skills are one of the three components of the World Bank's Digital São Tomé and Príncipe project, which runs to 2027 alongside its connectivity and digital public services work. The most recent set-piece was a national Data Governance Capacity Building Workshop on 9–10 July 2026 on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework domestically, run by the D4D Hub with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet. The data protection authority has been building its own bench through bilateral contact: a June 2025 visit to Portugal's CNPD put the training of data subjects, and of children and young people in particular, on the shared agenda alongside disinformation and video surveillance, and in June 2026 a delegation presented the country's data protection regime and its approach to supervising artificial intelligence in Macau, also calling on Hong Kong's Privacy Commissioner for Personal Data and a Guangdong cyber and data security association.

Research institutions

The research mandate sits with the institute that also builds the state's systems. INIC's revised statutes, approved in Council of Ministers in September 2021 and revoking its 2008 founding decree, give it scientific, administrative, financial and asset autonomy under the Prime Minister, and state its purpose as implanting the information and knowledge society, promoting research, development and technological innovation and coordinating the design of all state information systems, with a Centro de Excelencia em Desenvolvimento within its development directorate. No think tank, university department or research programme is recorded producing digital policy analysis.

Degree-level teaching is no longer confined to one institution - the accredited-courses register carries computing engineering at the university's Faculty of Sciences and Technologies and at ULSTP, and telecommunications and computer engineering and business computing at IUCAI - and in March 2026 the country launched a national scientific repository by videoconference alongside the CPLP common repository, which has run since 2021 and aggregates more than two and a half million documents, with the FCT, the Universidade do Minho and IBICT as implementing partners, the Director of Higher Education and Science describing it as a knowledge infrastructure and a mechanism of academic transparency.

Inclusion

Access to services

Public services reach social groups unevenly and a decade has not shifted it: the country scores 41.0 out of 100 for equal access to public services, 26th of 54 African states and half a point better than in 2014 (2023), while equal socioeconomic opportunity rose 12.4 points to 52.0.

Most of what the state and the banks provide runs through one document. The national identity card or cedula pessoal is required to open a bank account, activate a SIM, use basic public health services and join assistance programmes, a requirement resting on the 1971 civil identification law, and the digital identity register still holds a minority of residents (2022) though birth registration is close to universal. The card is not free to issue or renew, and the system is open only to nationals and the Santomean diaspora, with no route in for refugees, asylum seekers or permanent residents (2023).

Two routes have opened around cost and distance. A DGRN mobile brigade has been issuing the card free to citizens reaching majority in remote localities including Ilhéu das Rolas (January 2026), working off-grid over a satellite link, and the embassy in Lisbon has issued civil-registry documents directly from the SIGA register since April 2025, with cards from the "BI para Todos os São-Tomenses" campaign ready for collection there in June 2026.

Financial access binds anything built over payments: account ownership and banking reach rank among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators (2023), digital payment use is very low (2023) and no mobile money operator was in the market as at December 2021. Migrants have a legal basis for financial access through ECCAS free movement rights, but know-your-customer demands for proof of address and employment shut out informal workers, nothing accommodates refugees or asylum seekers, and a recommendation to issue consular identity cards remains outstanding (2025).

Three specific groups have something on the record. On disability, the second edition of the national sign-language dictionary, organised in 21 thematic areas with 470 gestures, added a QR code giving access through the internet in September 2025, and the incumbent operator handed adapted computer equipment to an association of blind and partially sighted people in June 2026, whose president said it continues to work for approval of the regulation of the disability law. On gender, the national gender-violence response protocol was validated in September 2025 with more than 80 participants and innovates by including terminology on digital violence and concepts relating to the LGBTQI+ public, and the 2025 activism campaign opened on the theme of ending digital violence against women and girls. On feedback, the project fiduciary agency publishes a grievance mechanism with a green line, a general complaints number, per-project email addresses including one for the digital project, and named physical complaint boxes across all districts and the Autonomous Region in schools, health posts, district councils and community premises - covering that agency's projects rather than the administration, and no national integrated complaints portal was located - while a youth participation platform passed 12,000 connected young people at its fifth anniversary in June 2026 and launched a girls' channel.

Digital delivery has come through narrow channels: conditional cash transfers to vulnerable families through the Ke-Non social protection system (2024), remote medical consultations in the underserved district of Caué (2026), and, for the electoral roll, a messaging app standing in for a citizen service interface (July 2026).

Digital divides

Satellite broadband arrived in December 2025 at a price that settles who it is for: Starlink's Residential plan launched at STN 1,700 a month, about US$79.5, with a Lite plan at about US$60.8, on top of a one-off charge for the hardware.

At those launch prices a Residential subscription takes a large share of average monthly output per head, which makes satellite service a complement to the incumbent's fixed and mobile network rather than a substitute for most households.

The sharpest divide is between the two islands. Príncipe's submarine cable supply contract was still unsigned in September 2025, the smaller island had no working fixed broadband to speak of, and none of the schools targeted for new connections had yet benefited. On the main island the incumbent has gone on extending reach — a new antenna at Água Izé, in Cantagalo district, was inaugurated in March 2026 after a prolonged spell of network instability there — while rural households remain further from mains electricity than urban ones (2023), which sets a floor under anything connectivity alone can close.

The instrument that would answer this is fourteen years old and its fund is unaccounted for. Decreto-Lei n. 19/2012 defines the scope of the universal telecommunications service and establishes the price-setting and financing regimes applicable to it, and is the basis of the Fundo de Servico Universal de Telecomunicacoes; nothing held records a disbursement from the fund, a designated provider's obligations or a coverage target set under it, and the copy held is hosted by the regional regulators' association rather than by a government site.

Access to networks has improved faster than the distribution of what the state delivers over them. The 2024 IIAG country profile records mobile communications among São Tomé and Príncipe's most improved indicators of the 2014-2023 decade, and internet and computer access rising from a low base, while its measure of equal access to public services barely moved across the same ten years.

Data

National statistics

Two of the country's longest-standing statistical gaps closed within a year of each other: enumeration for the housing and population census finished in December 2024 under a US$3 million component of the World Bank's Digital STP project, which also funds an updated master sampling frame, and the Ministry of Agriculture and the National Statistics Institute began collecting data for the third General Agricultural Census in July 2025. Both filled holes the World Bank had recorded: as at 2023 the Statistical Performance Indicators showed a population census held within the previous twenty years but no agricultural census and no economic or business census in that period - though the statistics institute's own record shows a business census had in fact been run, its second enterprise census reporting an employment table captioned 2019 and published in November 2021.

The field programme since has been dense for a country this size. The fifth population and housing census was enumerated from 15 November to 15 December 2024 and its results report published in July 2025, carrying population, household, housing and demographic results by district; the household budget survey returned to the field in March 2026 after nine years, with more than a hundred enumerators across the territory over two months and results expected by the end of the year; a 2025 enterprise survey was catalogued in January 2026, the first firm-level survey since 2014; and a new phase of tourism satellite accounts work opened in February 2026 with a national tourism survey at its centre, six of the ten accounts tables already complete. The plan behind them is the third of its kind: the national statistics development strategy for 2025-2029 succeeds the 2009-2018 and 2018-2021 plans, and the statistical system it organises still rests on Lei n. 5/98.

The survey record thins the same way. The same indicators register no agricultural survey, no business survey and no labour force survey in the past ten years, against two health surveys and one household survey (2023) — so employment, farm output and enterprise activity are all measured, when they are measured at all, from something

other than a recent national instrument. The banded scores locate the problem precisely: 50-69% on data use, data services and data products but only 20-49% on data sources and on data infrastructure (2023). What the system does with what it has outperforms what it is given to work with.

Capacity is nonetheless climbing. The IIAG's measure of whether the state can produce and publish reliable statistics rose 7.1 points over 2014-2023 to 49.2 out of 100, 26th of 54 African states. The residue shows up as absence in the international indices that draw on national reporting: the 2024 IIAG carries no data for São Tomé and Príncipe on four of its 96 indicators — Education Quality, Human Resources in Education, Rural Market Access and Enforcement of Environmental Policies (2023), and the country falls outside the economies covered by the Global Innovation Index 2024 altogether. Administrative sources are the stronger flank, with birth registration close to universal and an electoral roll republished with updated figures through the 2026 cycle. The clearest case of an administrative dataset driving an official register is now statutory: the automatic and permanent electoral registration law came into force on 26 March 2026, entering citizens in the electoral database ex officio on reaching 18 on the basis of data sharing between the registries directorate and the electoral commission. What administrative data has not produced is a published series: the health ministry's statistical yearbook, developed by the health information system office with a statistics institute representative on its working team, is the clearest recurring publication compiled from routine service records rather than a survey.

Open data

Publishing records and being able to get hold of them have come apart. The IIAG's measure of whether budgets, asset declarations and official documents are published rose 17.7 points over 2014-2023 to 28.7 out of 100, among São Tomé and Príncipe's ten most improved indicators, while its companion measure of whether citizens can actually obtain official records and use online government services gained 0.8 points over the same decade to 20.5, 39th of 54 African states and one of the country's ten worst-scoring indicators (2023). More is being put out; almost nothing has changed about reaching it.

The 2024 Open Data Inventory sets a low ceiling even where the country does best. Its strongest categories are economic: 6 out of 10 on the coverage and openness of balance of payments, government finance, international trade and money and banking statistics, 4.5 on national accounts and price statistics and 3 on labour statistics. Across the social and environmental categories that carry a score at all it sits between 3 and 5 — 4.5 for population, health facilities and reproductive health, 3.5 for education outcomes, health outcomes and gender, 3 for agriculture and natural resources, and none at all for crime and justice or for poverty and income. Nothing in the assessment reaches the upper half of the scale, which is consistent with the World Bank's finding that data sources and data infrastructure are the system's weakest pillars (2023).

The most reliable open publishing runs through the central bank rather than a government portal. The Banco Central de São Tomé e Príncipe posts payment system statistics covering internet banking from 2014, SICOI interbank clearing from 2013 and card payment operations from 2011, each series carrying its own update date. On the governance side the published material is the rulebook rather than the data: the National Framework for Interoperability sits on the INIC website with no accompanying public reporting on what moves through the data exchange it governs. The one act of reuse on record is civil society's rather than the state's: a citizen's budget for 2026 was built from the budget law as gazetted, summarising how the State plans to raise and spend public resources and linking to the official text, stated as intended to meet the budget transparency index. No specific law or regulation on open data exists, against personal-data provisions that do, and no government open data portal is held.

Use of satellite data

The largest movement in the country's observation data is a funded upgrade to ground instruments. In June 2026 a US$2.6 million investment was approved to upgrade two automatic weather stations and rehabilitate one upper-air station with training and management support, moving the country into the investment phase for global observation compliance, after equipment installed in January 2026 for the second island's meteorology delegation - a present-weather sensor measuring visibility and coding the weather, redundant pressure sensors and a tide gauge, following earlier installations at two ports and completing what the observer describes as the island's first complete aeronautical station. The standing assessment behind both is a peer review of the meteorological service prepared with the national institute, documenting its forecasting, observation and warning capability and the satellite products it draws on (May 2024).

On land the record is a reporting exercise rather than a service: the national multisectoral working group was trained in and used the Collect Earth tool to assess land occupation and land-occupation change, with country-level land-cover data collected through it as one of three land-degradation indicators and the agriculture ministry among the working-group institutions (July 2018). Nothing since records a repeat assessment, a national geospatial programme or an agricultural monitoring product.

Satellite reaches the country most visibly as connectivity. Starlink switched on service in São Tomé and Príncipe in December 2025, putting satellite broadband on retail sale in the islands. The activation was one of a batch across the continent in the same window, alongside Somalia, Chad, Lesotho, Guinea-Bissau and Congo, so it reflects a regional rollout schedule rather than anything particular to the country's market.

Entry was smoothed politically well before it happened: the United States chargé d'affaires, James Story, publicly backed the company's investment plans in February 2025 after meeting the President.

The entry price is set at the hardware. Kits launched at STN 5,500 for the Standard and STN 4,400 for the Mini — about US$257 and US$206 at December 2025 rates — before the monthly Residential and Lite subscriptions that run on top of them.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States chargé d'affaires in São Tomé and Príncipe, James Story, came out publicly for Starlink's entry to the country in February 2025 after meeting the President, putting the mission's weight behind one American operator in a market small enough that a single connectivity supplier can shape it. Service was switched on in December 2025, in the same window as activations in Somalia, Chad, Lesotho, Guinea-Bissau and Congo, which places the São Toméan opening inside a continental rollout rather than a bilateral arrangement.

American presence moved the other way at the same time. Washington closed its long-running Voice of America relay station in the country in 2025. Taken together the two moves describe the shape of United States engagement as it now stands: a commercial satellite subscription sold direct to households, in place of a state broadcasting installation with a physical footprint, staff and a standing obligation to keep transmitting. Nothing in the Starlink arrangement gives the government a lever over the service, and no hyperscaler has any other announced presence on the islands.

The formal bilateral frame is thin and the diplomatic one is not. The State Department's own country statement records that there are bilateral investment treaties with Angola, Cabo Verde, Mauritius and Portugal but none with the United States and no bilateral taxation treaty, and that the Development Finance Corporation is authorised to do

business in the country but has run no programmes there. Against that, a charge d'affaires visited in January 2026, meeting the Prime Minister and the Defence Minister on defence cooperation and discussing the recent launch of the satellite service, and in August 2026 the mission marked fifty years of diplomatic relations at a reception at which the delegation visited the coastguard headquarters and maritime operations control centre, described as ongoing cooperation on maritime security and Gulf of Guinea stability. The engagement that is growing is maritime security; the commercial one remains a subscription.

China activities

The relationship has a founding instrument and a headline frame, and neither is digital. The joint communique of 26 December 2016 resumed ambassadorial-level relations with immediate effect and records the country's recognition of one China and its undertaking to have no official relations or contacts with Taiwan, and in September 2024 the two heads of government announced the elevation of the relationship to a strategic partnership at a summit in Beijing. The joint declaration's own nine-point text commits both sides to deeper Belt and Road cooperation and to a stable expansion into what it names as new areas - the digital economy, green development and the blue economy - alongside the traditional fields of agriculture, health and infrastructure, naming no project, no instrument and no sum. The in-window content is health: a donation of essential medicines, surgical instruments and hospital equipment handed over in February 2026 under the FOCAC health partnership, and certificates of merit awarded to the nineteenth Chinese medical team on the conclusion of its mission in March 2026.

Macau, not Beijing, is China's channel into São Tomé and Príncipe's data governance: Macau's data protection bureau describes its agreements with São Tomé and Príncipe and Cabo Verde as strengthening "the chain of cooperation between China and the Portuguese-speaking countries in the areas of data security and protection of personal privacy" (August 2026). Macau casts itself as a "precision interlocutor" between the mainland and the Portuguese-speaking countries, running its outreach through the China–Portuguese-speaking Countries Forum (May 2026) — a framing that lets a Chinese engagement arrive in São Tomé in Portuguese, through an institution with no visible Beijing branding.

The relationship is now formal. Macau's bureau signed a cooperation memorandum with the ANPDP in June 2026, and a separate anti-money-laundering track was announced in August 2026, framed and announced apart from the data protection work rather than bundled into one package. Macau also joined the Rede Lusófona de Proteção de Dados in April 2026, which places it inside the same Portuguese-language regulatory network the ANPDP helped found — so the Chinese channel reaches São Tomé's regulator both bilaterally and through the body Portugal and Brazil run. What is being cultivated is a supervisory authority rather than a network or a data centre. That is a cheaper investment than infrastructure and a more durable one: the rules a small regulator learns, and the peers it learns them from, outlast any particular contract.

EU activities

The European Union's Electoral System Reform Project (PReSE) closed in September 2025, an EU-funded programme delivered through Camões / Portuguese Cooperation with the voter-registration platform built by the University of Aveiro. It was designed to answer the recommendations of the EU election observation mission of 2022, which is how European conditionality reached the country's registry systems: through the electoral roll, not through a digital strategy. The frame outlasted the funding — the registration reform behind the 2026 roll still sits under PReSE (July 2026), and the project's interoperability platform linking civil registration and the identity card to the roll was reported all but finished in September 2025.

European engagement here is mostly Portuguese engagement. The civil registration system SIGA is hosted in Portugal at the University of Aveiro, a foreign infrastructure dependency the World Bank flags as a business continuity risk (2024); the Dobra24 interbank platform runs on a system supplied by Portugal's SIBS; and the data protection authority is a founding member of the Lusophone network established in 2024, with Portugal holding the permanent secretariat. Brussels-level activity is larger than the digital work suggests. The delegation's own record states that relations are governed by the Samoa Agreement, that the 2021-2027 Multiannual Indicative Programme mobilised 13 million euros for 2021-2024 across governance, green transition and human development, and that about 5.3 million euros more came through regional programmes, and in October 2025 the Commission and the country signed a new four-year fisheries protocol for 2025-2029, allowing EU vessels around 6,500 tonnes of tuna and other migratory species a year for a contribution of 3.3 million euros over four years, of which 500,000 a year is earmarked for fisheries management, control and surveillance, artisanal fishing and local fishing communities. The digital share of that is the electoral project and its training. Team Europe's D4D Hub ran a national data governance workshop on 9–10 July 2026 on adopting the African Union Data Policy Framework, with GIZ, AUDA-NEPAD and KICTANet. The exposure this creates is not political but operational: the country's foundational registry, its payment switch and its electoral platform all depend on Portuguese institutions, and the machinery would not survive their withdrawal.

Gulf/UAE activities

The one Gulf-linked digital engagement on record is stated by a São Toméan consulate and by nobody else. The consulate in Berlin says that the country's Citizenship and Investment Unit has signed a contract with Atlas Sovereign Smart Solutions LLC, led by IOPn in partnership with Betabytes, to mobilise up to ten billion US dollars over the next ten years and to build national infrastructure including a modular data centre, an NVIDIA-certified AI academy, an AI factory, digital identity systems, a digital finance ministry and a Web3 free trade zone, funded from the citizenship-by-investment programme through a new National Transformation Fund (October 2025). The figure and the scope are that page's own claims, the page is written in German, no counterparty document was located, and nothing records any part of it as begun. Set against it, the largest external commitment to the country's digital economy is a US$22 million World Bank grant approved in June 2022.

The older instrument is not digital: an air transport services agreement was signed in October 2017 by the head of the UAE General Civil Aviation Authority and the country's then Minister of Infrastructure, Natural Resources and Environment.

India activities

India's digital presence in the country is a vendor rather than a programme. India's own consolidated country brief records Ooru Digital's MOSIP-based national digital identity and citizen portal work, funded by the World Bank and the Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure (March 2026) - the same system integrator a World Bank mission names on the foundational identity build, so the country's identity stack is being built by an Indian firm on an Indian-origin platform without an Indian financing instrument behind it.

The bilateral frame around it is old and mostly not digital. The same brief records a Protocol for Foreign Office Consultations signed in December 2009, an Agreement for Economic Cooperation and a memorandum on traditional medicines signed in March 2018, a Framework Agreement on Space Cooperation signed on 8 September 2018, signature and ratification of the International Solar Alliance framework, an NTPC 50kW solar installation at the Prime Minister's office, six school buses gifted in April 2025 and five occasions of humanitarian medical assistance, with the Embassy of India in São Tomé functioning since 21 September 2020. The in-window activity is a workshop marking the tenth Ayurveda Day in September 2025, attended by senior officers of the health ministry and practitioners of traditional medicine, under the 2018 memorandum.

Digital sovereignty

São Tomé and Príncipe's identity system, its central database and its fingerprint system were developed in-house and run on a server at the registry directorate's headquarters, with the backup server in the same building (2024). The SIGA civil register was built by the directorate's own technicians with the University of Aveiro under a 2016 agreement with Portugal's Camões institute, and the university still maintains and updates it and hosts its infrastructure, SIGA connecting to servers in Portugal for every registration and document issued, with no redundancy in the country (2024).

The 2021 national interoperability framework accepts proprietary standards only as a transition in legacy systems or where no open standard exists, and counts a standard as open only where its intellectual property rights have been made available to the Republic in full and irrevocably. The terms on which the passport contract with Portugal's Imprensa Nacional-Casa da Moeda and SIBS's supply of the Dobra24 payment switch govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026. No instrument fixing where state data is held or under whose law it is processed was in force as at September 2026. Where the model and data behind the DireitosAoPovo.st justice chatbot will be hosted had not been published as at September 2026.

Officials from São Tomé and Príncipe joined the second Lusophone Africa data governance workshop in Luanda in June 2026, hosted by Angola's data protection agency with Smart Africa, the World Bank, CETIC.br and UNESCO, on data centres, cloud infrastructure, interoperability and cross-border data flows.

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